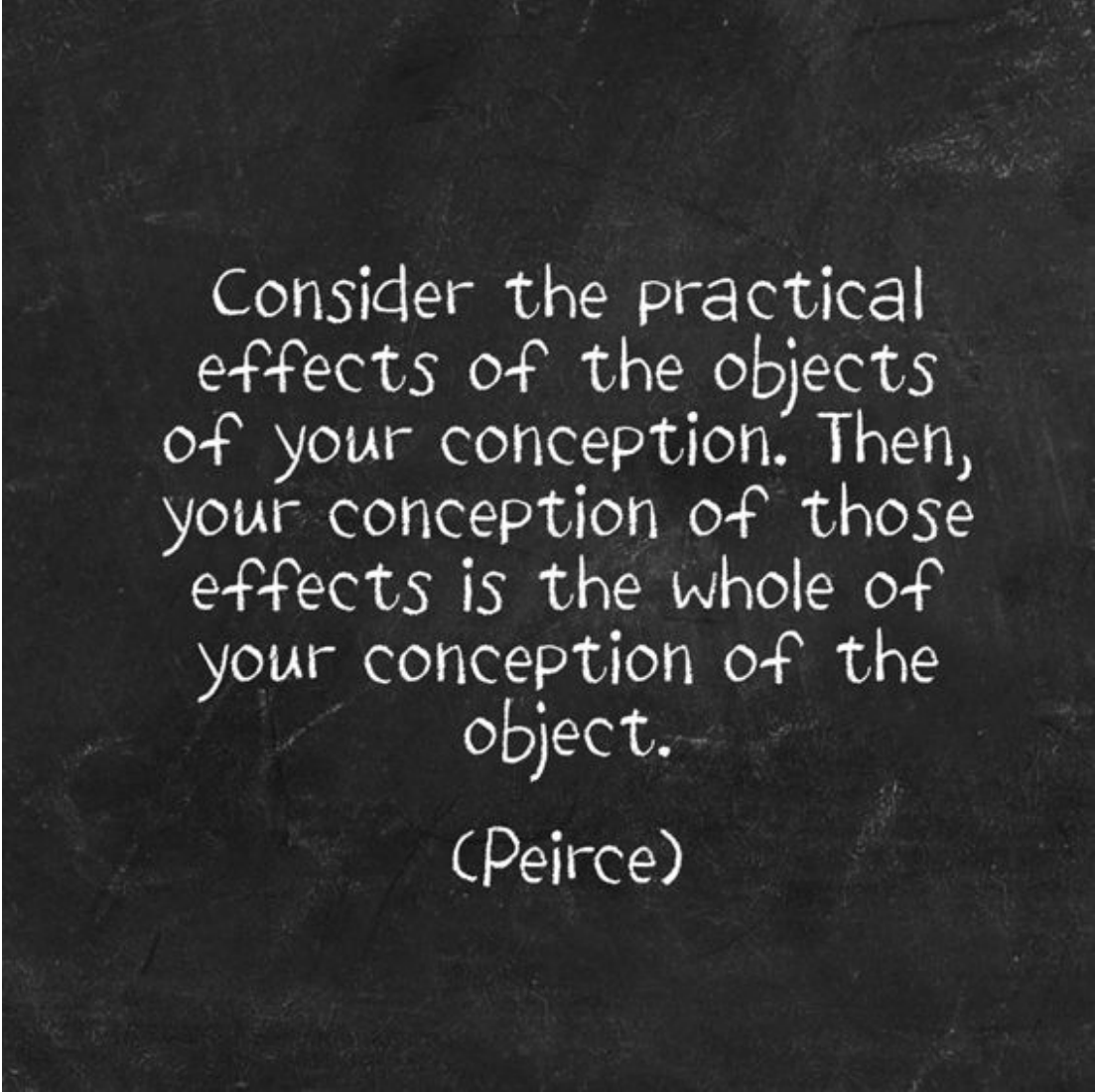


Pragmatism



Consider the practical
effects of the objects
of your conception. Then,
your conception of those
effects is the whole of
your conception of the
object.

(Peirce)

From the scientist's standpoint, philosophical discussion of knowledge, reality and truth can appear to be merely debate about words, rather than the world we live in. As a mathematician and logician, C.S. Peirce felt that philosophical enquiry often fell into this trap, resulting in conceptions that were not practically useful. He proposed a different approach, using what he later called the pragmatic maxim: 'Consider the practical effects of the objects of your conception. Then, your conception of those effects is the whole of your conception of the object.' To understand the meaning of something, we should examine whether it makes any difference to a

situation or problem – something that has no effect that we can discern with our senses effectively has no meaning for the pragmatist. Pragmatism is concerned not so much with the truth of a statement, as the practical applications of accepting it to be true. Knowledge is not then made up of truths and certainties, but of valid explanations, which can be replaced or improved upon when they are no longer valid or useful.